

Bulging Eyes

(Exophthalmos; Proptosis)

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Bulging or protruding of one or both eyes is called proptosis or exophthalmos. Exophthalmos is usually used when describing bulging eyes caused by Graves disease, a disorder causing overactivity of the thyroid gland ([hyperthyroidism](#)). Bulging eyes are not the same as prominent eyes. Some disorders that may change the appearance of the face and eyes but that do not cause true eye bulging include [Cushing disease](#) and severe obesity.

Bulging Eye (Proptosis)



The most common cause of a bulging or protruding eye in adults is Graves disease, which most often causes bulging in both eyes.

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Bulging sometimes causes other symptoms. The eyes may be dry and irritated (which causes watering) because the bulging may prevent the eyelids from closing properly. Also, people may blink less often or may appear to stare. Depending on the cause of bulging, people may have other symptoms such as [double vision](#) or difficulty focusing on objects. If bulging is prolonged, the optic nerve is stretched, which may impair vision. Vision may also be impaired if the disorder causing bulging also presses on the optic nerve.

Causes of Bulging Eye

The **most common cause** in adults is [Graves disease](#), which causes swelling of tissue behind and around the eye, pushing the eyeball forward. In children, the most common cause is infection.

Other causes are uncommon. They include tumors, bleeding, infections (in adults), and, rarely, inflammation of structures within the orbit without infection (called [orbital pseudotumor](#)). Glaucoma that is present from birth ([primary infantile glaucoma](#)) can cause the eyes to enlarge, which may seem to look similar to eyes that are pushed forward.



Some Causes and Features of Bulging Eyes

Cause	Common Features*	Tests
<u>Graves disease</u>	<i>Eye symptoms:</i> Pain, watering, dryness, irritation, sensitivity to light, double vision, and loss of vision	
	Usually affecting both eyes <i>General symptoms:</i> Palpitations, anxiety, increased appetite, weight loss, diarrhea, inability to tolerate heat, increased sweating, and insomnia	Blood tests to evaluate thyroid gland function Sometimes, CT or MRI of the orbits
<u>Orbital cellulitis</u> (infection of the tissue within the eye socket, or orbit)	Affecting only one eye Eye redness, pain deep within the eye, pain when moving the eye, and aches in and around the eye	
	Red and swollen eyelids Inability to fully move the eye in all directions	CT or MRI of the brain and orbit
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	Impaired vision or loss of vision Fever Sometimes preceded by symptoms of sinusitis	